

constant round of births and deaths does not appear to have interrupted Bach's productivity, nor to have disturbed what was a mutually contented marriage.

In contrast, Bach's relations with his Leipzig employers were always difficult. There were endless conflicts over pay and status, and over the nonmusical teaching duties that he was supposed to have performed but often did not. In 1736, he secured an additional post as court composer to the elector of Saxony in Dresden, a prestigious position that made him largely immune to any further criticism from the Leipzig authorities. It was at the Dresden court that Bach received a commission from the Russian ambassador, Count Keyserlingk, to write a soothing piece of music for harpsichordist Gottlieb Goldberg to play to help the count sleep at night—the work now known as the Goldberg Variations.

